

The Speed of an Answer

At the UN's first global AI-governance dialogue, the urgent question was not whether machines can think, but whether people will leave enough room to do so.

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On 6 July, diplomats, officials and technologists gathered at Geneva's Palexpo for the first Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance. The meeting ran alongside the World Summit on the Information Society and the AI for Good Global Summit: an almost too-perfect arrangement of names for a moment when hope and anxiety are sharing the same room. Opening the dialogue, United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres said AI was advancing at "runaway speed" - faster, he warned, than even its builders could keep up with. It is easy to hear that as a story about machines. It is more usefully heard as a story about us. We have become very good at making answers arrive before the question has settled. A draft appears before a thought has ripened. A recommendation enters the room before everyone has spoken. A tool promises to return the time it saves, yet the reclaimed minute is often immediately filled with another demand.

The tension is not simply between innovation and restraint. It is between velocity and judgment. Speed can be humane: it can shorten a diagnosis, translate a needed sentence, expose a pattern no person could find alone. But judgment asks a different kind of time. It asks whether the useful thing is also the right thing, for whom, and at what cost. Those questions do not become less important because the reply field is blinking.

"Judgment needs a kind of time that no answer generator can supply."

A pause inside the machinery

Hannah Arendt understood thinking not as the possession of clever opinions, but as a pause within action - a private conversation in which a person tests what they are about to do. Her concern was not that people would become stupid. It was that they might become thoughtless: busy, compliant, efficient, and no longer in the habit of asking whether they could live with the consequences of their own decisions.

That is a useful lens for the gathering in Geneva. Rules matter, because the effects of artificial intelligence spill across borders: work, education, information, security and access to opportunity. The UN dialogue exists precisely because no government can settle those consequences alone. Yet the deeper work cannot be outsourced to a summit, a standards body, or an ethics label. Governance begins wherever someone has the power to deploy a system and chooses to ask a second question.

The second question is modest. Before sending the AI-written note, do I stand behind its claim? Before using a model to rank applicants, decide a price, summarize a person, or nudge a customer, have I noticed what has been flattened to make the decision fast? Before accepting a fluent answer, have I remembered that fluency is not understanding? These are not anti-technology questions. They are pro-responsibility questions. Ordinary life offers a practice. Build one small delay into any consequential use of an intelligent tool. Name the person who might be missed. Check one source. Read the final line aloud. Ask a colleague to find the assumption that feels invisible. The delay need not be theatrical. Its point is to restore authorship: to make sure the human being has not become merely the last, inattentive link in an automated chain.

There is also a gentler reason to resist the cult of instant answers. A life wholly optimized for response can lose its capacity for attention. We begin to treat uncertainty as a defect, silence as wasted space, and one another as prompts awaiting completion. But friendship, grief, repair, and good work rarely arrive on demand. They ask for presence before they offer clarity.

Geneva's dialogue will not, by itself, slow a technology whose progress is distributed among laboratories, markets and millions of daily choices. Still, it names the right ambition: shared power should be met with shared responsibility. The practical version of that ambition is available to each of us today. Do not merely ask what an answer can do. Ask what kind of person you become when you let it answer first.

When the world becomes faster at replying, where will you keep the time to decide?

SOURCES NOTE

United Nations, *Secretary-General's remarks to the opening of the first Global Dialogue on AI Governance* (6 July 2026), un.org/sg/en/content/sg/statements/2026-07-06/secretary-generals-remarks-the-opening-of-the-first-global-dialogue-artificial-intelligence-governance-delivered. UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance, *Home and FAQ*, un.org/global-dialogue-ai-governance/en. UNESCO, *Global Dialogue on AI Governance, Geneva, 6-7 July*, unesco.org/en/articles/global-dialogue-ai-governance-geneva-6-7-july. Philosophical lens: Hannah Arendt's account of thinking and responsibility, especially *The Life of the Mind* (1978).